

BEGGAR'S BANQUET

Beggars can't be choosers, they say. Not really. It's a choice profession for many, and with good reasons. New surveys raise uneasy questions about the world's largest begging population.

■ By Damayanti Datta

Behra tells lies. During the course of a single chat, he recounts his life story several times—in one he rescues a drowning child, in another he slaps a policeman—with the details varying so dramatically that he might be talking about totally different people. Depending on which version you believe, Behra was born in Bihar, or in Uttar Pradesh; he is a school dropout, or never went to school; he was married twice, or never. He may be 35, or 45. He claims to be alone in the world, but when asked if he would allow himself to be photographed, he balks: "What if my family members see me in your magazine in this condition?"

His 'condition' is the one certain truth about Behra: he is a beggar. A face among the nation's over 60 lakh vagrants—the world's largest. Yet another disquieting presence in the midst of India's new plenty—indistinguishable from criminals, divorced from social systems, inhabiting hidden depths within cities. How well does the nation know him? "Not well enough. Very few studies have been done on beggary in India," says Sneh Lata Tandon, who heads Delhi School of Social Work (DSSW) and completed a survey on 5,003 beggars in 2007.

With the nation aspiring to world standards in conspicuous consumption, and a Commonwealth Games looming, there's a rush to "fix this urban nuisance" now. The upshot is a rash of new surveys; and what emerges is an eye-opener on the country's teeming underbelly.

On this bitterly cold night, Behra is not alone. He and his friends—tramps, thieves, sex workers, pimps—crowd

his feet. But these interludes rarely last long. Behra finds prolonged human company stressful and is deeply wary of anything that smacks of officialdom. "The shelters are okay for a bath and medical treatment," he says, "but not for long term."

Finding "long-term" solutions for people like Behra is an enormous—and growing—challenge for India, where vagrancy has quietly been climbing to new heights. In a decade since 1991, their number has gone up by a lakh. There are some 60,000 beggars in Delhi, reports DSSW; over 3,00,000 in Mumbai, according to a 2004 ActionAid report; nearly 75,000 in Kolkata, says the Beggar Research Institute—the world's only; 56,000 in Bangalore, according to police records. In Hyderabad, one in every 354 people is engaged in begging, found out the Council of Human Welfare in 2005. In every Indian city, they are anywhere a fly could land—in rubbish dumps, at the road's edge, on traffic islands, under flyovers. The frail, the crippled and the mentally ill share space with children, women and able-bodied men.

It's an inferno one can easily slip into. A reality that hit the nation hard last year when Gitanjali Nagpal, a former model, was found living off the

streets. The media may have given her a new lease of life, but she's not alone. In January 2007, Prafulla Chiplunkar, an IT engineer and the grandson of freedom fighter Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, was found roaming on the streets of Pune. A series of personal misfortunes and severe depression had pushed him to the streets. These are not one-off examples. The DSSW surveyors came across 10 graduates and postgraduates who supplement monthly income by begging over the weekends.

The line that separates beggars from the casual poor is getting slimmer in a country where one in every four goes to bed hungry every night and 78 million are homeless. Over 71 per cent (compared to just 34 per cent in 1959) of Delhi's beggars are driven by



Source: Survey by Dept. of Social Work, Delhi University

together under the ISBT flyover in Delhi. All thin as rakes, all united in poverty, all clutching on to whatever little they've got. Behra makes a bed of flattened cardboard boxes and rests his tousled head on a sack containing all his worldly possessions. Sometimes he goes to one of the 12 beggar homes in Delhi, to get out of inclement weather or to have a doctor look at the sores on

50 a day, 27% up to Rs 100 MOST earn more than daily wage earners